

FREIDA PINTO, 24

“I can finally do something that I’m really passionate about.”

She’s sitting at the doctor’s clinic in Los Angeles nursing a sore throat and a 102 fever, but Freida Pinto is still the girl of the moment, one minute denying she has a secret husband, another minute being accused of having her complexion lightened for a *Vanity Fair* 50s pin-up shoot. Barely a month old on the celebrity circuit, Pinto seems to have been to the manner born, whether it is gushing on *Oprah* or playfully stroking host Jay Leno’s hair on *The Tonight Show*. She speaks easily, with the right amount of self-deprecation, is fashionably thin and by all accounts footloose

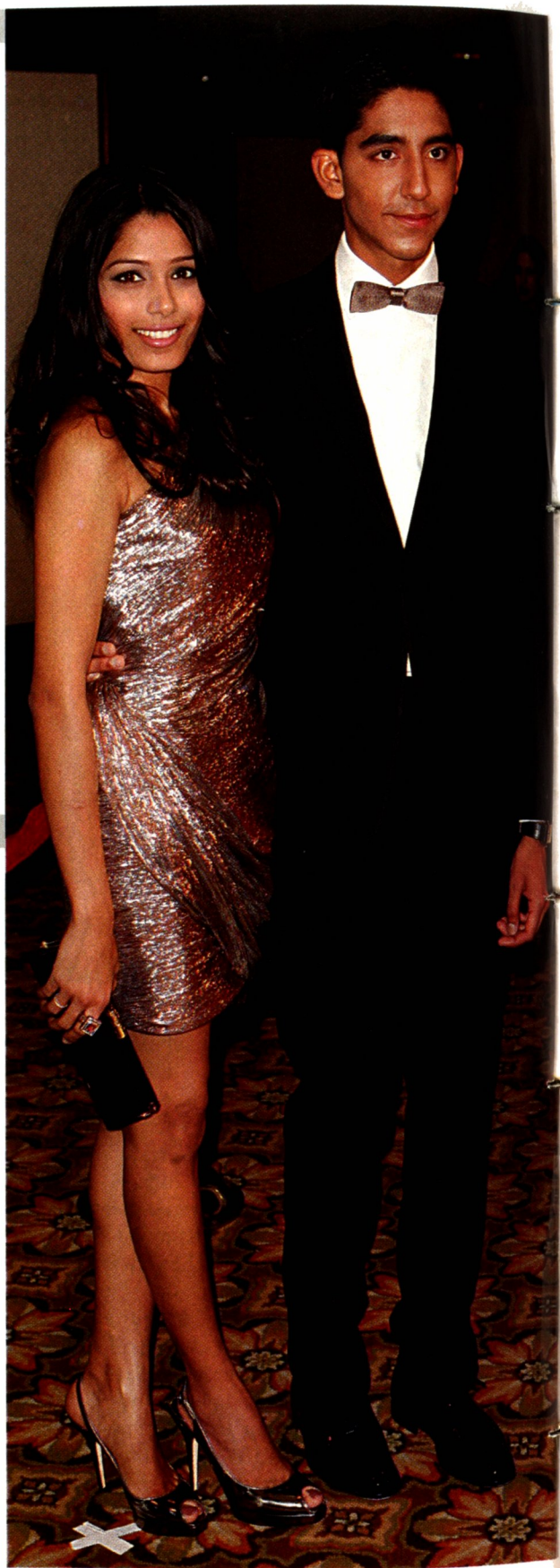
enough to travel frequently to the US while chasing a career through newly acquired powerhouse agents Creative Artists Agency. Her frocks have rocked the red carpets, whether it is a glittering Zac Posen at the Directors Guild of America awards or the pink Oscar de la Renta at the BAFTAs. She’s made gossip girls of Kate Winslet and Angelina Jolie on the Golden Globe and SAG red carpets. For the St. Xavier’s College graduate and former Elite model, the SAG award for best ensemble cast was the “moment when I realised that our little film has made it big. Before that it was just a blur.”

DEV PATEL, 19

“Having the chance to go to India, it’s like I found another piece of myself.”

He’s the guy who beat the beefed-up Muzammil Ibrahim and the pretty boy Ruslaan Mumtaz for the role. All of 19, with funny-stick-out ears and a raunchy appearance on a British television show called *Skins* being his only previous experience, Patel went through a grinding audition and welcome-to-India process, having spent his brief youth in London. But the world, especially after winning the best young actor/actress category at the Critics’ Choice Awards in Santa Monica, California, has opened its doors for him, as he moves seamlessly from *Late Night with David Letterman* right after

Katie Couric to burning up the floor in a Bollywood dance with Pinto on the *Ellen DeGeneres* show. The tabloids love him, running stories about his mother nagging him to make his bed and snapping him at Heathrow on his way home. The sudden elevation to a world of waiting limos and Beverly Hills hotel business meetings has caught him by surprise but having edged out Jesse McCartney for a role in Manoj Night Shyamalan’s *Avatar: The Last Airbender*, to be produced by Paramount Pictures, it looks like the taekwondo black belt is on his way to a fighting start. Not surprisingly, his favourite word these days is surreal.



AP PHOTO/MATT SAYLE